

Voicemail Villains

Prompt: We had possession of the box Dr. Janek was working on, but it was unceremoniously taken away from us. Fortunately, we received a voice mail message that we hope contains clues on where to find it. Can you help us pinpoint its location? We are looking for a full postal street address with no spaces, punctuation, or special characters using the ACR{flag} notation.

Flag: ACR{487NM333TijerasNM87059}

This one is based on a plot mechanic in the movie “Sneakers.” Bishop was kidnapped and locked in the trunk of a car. Later, his team figured out where he was taken based on what he remembered hearing during the drive. That turned out to be PlayTronics offices.

This puzzle can be solved by listening closely to the “VoiceMailVillains_FinalChallenge.wav” audio file. As one of the villains is leaving the voice mail, it is apparent from the traffic noise that he is riding on the highway. After he fails to terminate the call, a follow-on conversation with a passenger reveals that they have the box and are within a 2-minute driving radius of a library where they intend to deliver the box to Cosmo in approximately an hour.

There are a lot of libraries in the United States, but the search can be narrowed down considerably by listening very carefully to the audio. During the conversation between the villains, the tire road noise can be heard that very faintly sounds like “America the Beautiful.” They are driving on a musical highway.

Musical highways are engineered with precisely spaced grooves that cause a vehicle's tires to play a recognizable melody when driven at a specific speed. Most were built as tourism attractions or to encourage drivers to maintain the posted speed limit, with famous examples found in Japan, South Korea, Hungary, Denmark, and a few locations in the United States.

One of the locations in the United States is just outside of Albuquerque on Route 66 and plays “America the Beautiful.” It is on the eastbound lanes heading toward Tijeras which is about two minutes away. That city hosts the East Mountain Public Library. The street address is listed on their website.

(The highway plays slightly less than 15 seconds of the song. “America! America! God shed His grace on thee, And crown thy good with brotherhood, From sea to shining sea!” It starts when Villain #2 says “He’ll kill us” at just before the 1:00 minute mark. As Villain #2 says “I guess but I don’t like it, the final strains of “From Sea to Shining Sea” can be heard. Yes, the audio is very faint. It is meant to be hard to find.)



East Mountain Library

487 NM 333

Tijeras, NM 87059

505-281-8508

eastmountain@cabq.gov

[Amy Perry](#), Branch Manager

The flag is ACR{487NM333TijerasNM87059}

Red Herrings

The wav file has a lot of embedded information that is not needed to find the locations. However, two pieces of that are intended as clues. “The key is C major” will probably make people look for an encrypted message to decrypt using that as a key, but the second meaning is the musical key of a song, and the “America the Beautiful” on this track is indeed in C major. A second string says “Whistle while you work” which is a nod to the Sneaker’s character “Whistler” who was constantly reminding his teammates to just listen.

Everything else is a distraction, including a the 3G interference noise just before the call “drop” which sounds like embedded data, the album art, and the fictional song lyrics.

